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Date Submitted: August 29, 2025

Target User Group

Gig Economy Delivery Drivers in urban areas (Doordash, UberEats, InstaCart, etc)

Problem Description

Food delivery drivers face unfair pay structures, safety risks, and personal asset costs associated with the job. Many drivers report that customer tips are inconsistent, base pay is seemingly unpredictable, and the platform algorithms can deactivate or give preference to workers without clear explanation. This lack of stability makes it difficult for drivers to rely on delivery work as a sustainable income source. Additionally, drivers often face harassment and unsafe delivery conditions.

Evidence of the Problem

- A 2022 survey conducted by the Shift Project found that 14% of gig workers earned less than federal minimum wage and 29% earned less than their state's minimum wage.
- A 2023 survey by Worker Info Exchange found that 32% of delivery drivers experienced account deactivation without explanation.

"How Might We" Statement

How might we create greater income stability and safety protections for food delivery drivers while ensuring fairness in gig economy platforms?

User Persona

Name: Judy Brothers
Age: 27
Occupation: Full-time DoorDash Driver
Location: Mayfield, KY
Goals: Earn consistent income to cover rent and save for trade school
Frustrations: Unpredictable pay, high gas expenses, no health insurance, fear of being deactivated without recourse
Technology Comfort Level: High (Uses smartphone constantly for work)

Ethical Lens Applied

Principle: Fairness and harm reduction

- **Application:** Gig workers are being exploited when pay structures fail to meet minimum wage standards and when safety risks are ignored. This violates fairness and puts workers at risk of economic harm.

- **Stakeholders Impacted:** Delivery drivers, customers relying on safe/effective services, gig economy platforms, and policymakers

- **Professional Standard:** Aligns with ACM Code of Ethics 1.2 (“Avoid harm”) and 1.4 (“Be fair and take action not to discriminate”), as arbitrary algorithmic deactivation without recourse is unfair and harmful to workers.